The Last Incursion

A Doomsday narrative in a prologue, three acts, a final act and an epilogue

Story treatment for a lore-driven, cinematic CTF. Written to be filmed in Unreal Engine 5: every scene has a place, a light and a sound.

Before You Read

Canon anchors (kept faithful): Victor von Doom and his origin; Latveria and its capital, Doomstadt; the mask put on while still glowing from the forge; the Doombots; Doom's rivalry with Reed Richards; the Incursions of the Hickman-era comics; Doom's brush with godhood in Secret Wars; Doctor Strange, Wanda Maximoff and Cassandra Nova as their fans know them; Kristoff Vernard as Doom's heir by tradition.

Original inventions (free to adjust): the Cicada Concord and its Ferryman; the Remnant (the challengers); the Keystone Throne; the Road of Ash, the Bridge of Bells and the Ash Gate; the structure of the last hour; the Final Act.

Three rules of this telling: Doom is never made foolish. No hero is humiliated. Every defeat on the page is a choice made by someone who could have chosen otherwise.

Thirteen questions run through the story. Each is planted early, hinted in the middle and answered late, so that a reader who pays attention can solve the plot before the plot says it aloud. They are listed in Appendix C, with where each is planted, where it is answered and what a player must research to reach it.

Prologue: The Ferry of the Prime Hour

The Last Station

At the end of the last road there is a station where no train has stopped in years.

It sits on the shore of a black salt lake a thousand miles from anything that still has a name, its platforms half-drowned, its clock frozen at an hour no one remembers. Thousands wait here. They arrived on foot, by wrecked bus, by stolen aircraft that gave out over the dunes. They belong to no single nation, because the nations are gone. They are called the Remnant, and they share one thing: each of them has watched a world die.

Above the lake, the sky is wrong.

There is a second Earth up there. Not a moon, not a trick of cloud. A world, vast and slow, its oceans catching the light and its cities glowing on the night side like scattered coals. It resembles their own world the way a cousin resembles a face: close enough to ache, different enough to frighten. Every night it hangs a little lower. Every night the lake trembles at its pull.

Cinematic note: open on a wide, silent shot of the drowned station under a sky split between two worlds. No score, only low wind and the faint ticking of insects in the dark. Hold for ten seconds before the first cicada call.

Faces at the Station

Four hundred and twelve people wait on the platforms, and each of them is carrying something.

Maren Voss, a retired music teacher, carries a tuning fork wrapped in a scarf. She has counted every step of the road that brought her here, because counting is how she keeps from thinking. Ilya, an engineer from a city that no longer has a river, carries a notebook of measurements for a bridge that will never be built. Dalia, a locksmith, carries a roll of picks and no memory of what she used to open. A boy no older than twelve carries nothing at all, because the people who would have given him something are gone.

They do not trust one another. They arrived from different ruins under different banners, and in the last hours the banners have hardened into factions. A company from the drowned coast will not share a fire with a company from the burned plains. A group of scholars keeps its notes to itself. Everyone watches everyone's hands.

What they share is a number. Four hundred and twelve is the count the Ferryman has agreed to carry, and the Ferryman does not bend it. Maren hears it said a dozen times that night, in a dozen voices, and each time she feels the number settle into her like a stone.

What the Survivors Know

The scholars of many worlds have a word for it: an Incursion. Two realities drift into the same place in the dark between worlds, and when they touch, one of them must be destroyed, or both will be. No one understands why it began. Everyone understands how it ends.

Once there was a secret council of the cleverest minds a world could produce: a sorcerer, an inventor, a scientist, a king. They met in the dark and made terrible choices, trying to stop the collisions one by one. They failed. The survivors drew a simple lesson from that failure: no hero can out-think the end. One Earth collided with another, and one Earth fell, and each fall pushed the Remnant a little closer to the edge.

Now there is only the last Incursion, and one place in the world the cracks have not touched.

The Cicada Concord

No one can say exactly when the Concord began. Its own records say it started after the first Incursion, with a handful of people who had been buried alive in a collapsing world and dug themselves out seventeen years later, thin as wire, to find that no one remembered where they had come from. They made a vow in the dark and have never broken it: they would carry the record of what had been, for whoever was left to ask, and they would never decide who deserved to be remembered.

They took the cicada for their sign because it spends years underground, waiting, and rises in a roar when the number is right. They count in primes, the numbers that cannot be divided, because a prime is a thing that stays itself. Their seal is a brass insect with folded wings, stamped with a number that has never been seen to change: **3301**.

There are three of them at the crossing. The Ferryman carries. The Cartographer draws. The Notary counts. The Remnant have met only the first, but Maren, who notices small things, has seen two other lanterns burning at the edge of the water, and has not told anyone.

When she asks the Ferryman why the Concord would help both Doom and the people who mean to take from him, the answer is plain and unhelpful.

“A record that takes sides is not a record,” says the Ferryman. “It is a weapon.”

The Dossier of the Ferry

On the night before the crossing, the Ferryman reads to them.

The Ferryman is a figure in a hooded cloak the color of dead leaves, face hidden behind a mask of folded bronze wings. Nobody has ever seen the Ferryman sleep. The Ferryman carries a lantern whose light never flickers and a book whose pages are never the same twice.

“You will meet a man at the top of the mountain,” the Ferryman says. “You cannot bargain with him. You cannot flatter him. You may learn him. Listen.”

The Dossier begins.

Victor von Doom was born to the travelling Roma of Latveria, a small, hard country in the folds of Eastern Europe, a place of mountain passes, old stone and older grievances. His mother, Cynthia, was a witch who knew too much of what lay beneath the world. She bargained with a demon named Mephisto for the power to protect her people, and when the bill came due, her soul was the price. She was lost, and her son was left with the one idea he would never put down: that a debt like that could be settled by anyone brilliant enough, stubborn enough and proud enough.

He was all three. He went west on a scholarship to a university where the sciences were taught like gospel, and there he met a man named Reed Richards, an equal he could not forgive for being his equal. Victor built a machine meant to reach beyond death. Reed saw a flaw in the calculations and said so. The machine failed. Victor’s face was scarred, he was expelled, and the rivalry between the two men became a thing with its own gravity.

Victor wandered east, to a monastery in the high mountains, where monks gave him shelter and a forge. He built his armor with his own hands. When the mask was done, he could not wait for it to cool. He lifted it from the fire and set it on his face while it still glowed, and the pain that followed became part of the vow. Whatever Victor had been ended there. What walked down the mountain was Doom.

He returned to Latveria and took it, with competence before cruelty. The country prospered. The people were fed. The borders were closed. Latverians do not speak of Doom the way other nations speak of rulers; they speak of him the way sailors speak of weather. He fields armies of Doombots, mechanical copies of himself that serve and sometimes stand in for him, so that few who meet “Doom” can be certain whom they have met. He moves between science and sorcery without ever calling either a weakness.

Once, in a catastrophe that swallowed worlds, he reached for a power no mortal should hold, and held it. For a time he ruled a patchwork world stitched from the wreckage of many others, and the sorcerer who had once defended Earth stood at his side, because no one else could keep the stitches from tearing. When that world ended, they say, Doom lost what he had taken.

The Ferryman closes the book.

“They say he lost it,” the Ferryman says. “Look at the sky.”

Maren raises her hand, the way she once did in a classroom. “What did he lose?” she asks.

The Ferryman is quiet for a long time. “That is the wrong question,” the Ferryman says at last. “Ask what stayed.”

The Decree

The decree arrived three nights ago, through every radio that still worked and every mirror that still held a reflection.

“On the day of the last Incursion, for one hour, the gates of Doomstadt will open. Doom holds what you need. Come and take it. Doom does not promise that you will live.”

Nothing more. No signature was needed.

Latveria sealed its borders when the sky began to crack. The mountains are patrolled by machines. The passes are mined with spells. There is exactly one road in, and it begins at a ferry that no army controls.

Around the fires that night, the Remnant argue about it.

The first theory is that the decree is a trap: a man who rules by fear would take pleasure in drawing the desperate to his gates, and the road is a slaughterhouse dressed as a promise. The second is that it is a boast, a tyrant’s way of saying that nothing in the world can touch him. The third, offered by a scholar who has not slept in two days, is that no one in history has ever opened a border to the people who most wanted to cross it unless he needed them to arrive.

Nobody asks why it is only one hour. The scholar mentions it once and is shouted down. An hour is too short to storm a kingdom. An hour is too short to walk three miles uphill. An hour is too short for anything except a decision.

But the number lodges in Maren’s head, and so does another. In her sleep she hears bells, and she cannot tell how many.

The Crossing

At the Prime Hour, the Ferryman lights the lantern. The lake goes still.

The ferry is long and low and silent, its hull ribbed like the underside of a leaf. As the Remnant board, each is handed a small brass cicada, cold in the palm: a seal, a pass and, though they do not yet know it, a key.

Out on the water, the insects begin to sing. Not hundreds. Millions. The sound swells into a wall, then a roof, and then the lake itself seems to breathe. Swarms rise from the shore and spread above the ferry like a living canopy, hiding the cracks in the sky.

Cinematic note: the swarm forms a corridor of wings across the black water, lit from within by the lantern. Cut to a drone shot rising above the swarm to reveal the far shore: mountains, snow and, high on a cliff, a castle with light in every window.

At the far jetty, they step ashore. Behind them, in the shadow of the pier, the Ferryman meets a second figure: a Latverian herald in green, pale as the moon. The Ferryman hands over a sealed ledger. The herald opens it. Names. Every name of every person on that ferry.

The herald counts the names against the faces filing past him, and his lips move. He reaches the end and frowns. He begins again. The second count does not match the first. He glances at the Ferryman, who stands motionless with the lantern, and decides, wisely, to blame the dark.

“You sold us,” someone in the crowd says.

The Ferryman does not look up. “We carry,” the Ferryman says. “We do not choose.”

Then the ferry pushes off into the dark, and the cicadas fall silent. Above the shore, the gates of Doomstadt are waiting.

The Other Shore

On the far side of the sky, at another station, another crowd is looking up.

It is the same black water, the same drowned platforms, the same clock stopped at the same hour. The people on the platforms are dressed differently and speak in other languages. But they stand the same way, faces turned to the heavens, hands closed around the last things they own. Above them hangs a world whose oceans catch the light and whose cities glow in the dark like coals. They do not call it the second Earth. They call it *ours*.

A lantern burns at the edge of their water too. A cloaked figure lifts it. And somewhere in the dark behind that figure, a ledger opens to a page that reads exactly like the one on this shore.

Cinematic note: cut hard from the Ferryman’s lantern to a mirror image of the same scene, reversed. Hold each shot for one beat and let the audience feel the inversion before they understand it.

Act I: The Gates of Doomstadt

The night does not end at dawn in Latveria. The hour is kept by the cracks in the sky, not by the sun, and by the time the Remnant stand before the gates the second Earth already fills a quarter of the heavens. They have crossed the water. They have not yet crossed the country.

The Hour of Opening

The gates of Doomstadt are forty feet of black iron, braced with ribs of green-lit steel, set into a wall that is older than the country that now owns it. Braziers burn with a flame the wrong shade of green. Along the parapets, thousands of Latverian Guard stand in perfect silence, iron-grey armor, green cloaks, faces hidden behind plain steel half-masks. Between their ranks, Doombots wait with the stillness of things that do not tire. Each one wears Doom's mask. Each one watches the Remnant arrive.

A Marshal in a half-mask of scarred iron steps forward and reads the decree again, for the record. His name is Orlek, and he reads it without contempt, the way a priest reads a rite.

"One hour," he says. "The road is open. Doom is patient. The army is not."

Overhead, the second Earth lowers. Fissures branch across the heavens like frost on glass, and through them seeps a light that belongs to no sun. The mountains hum. In the throne room of Castle Doom, a single bell tolls once, and the sound rolls down the mountain.

The gates open without a hand upon them.

Cinematic note: a low-angle shot from the Remnant's side, the gates parting in slow motion, green light spilling over the cobbles. Hold the camera at the height of a child. Everything about this place should feel built for someone much larger.

The Marshal's Orders

On the parapet above the gates, Marshal Orlek watches the Remnant stream through and does not draw his sword.

His orders are four lines long, and he has read them so many times that the paper has gone soft. *Hold the road for one hour. Do not pursue those who turn back. Do not stop those who understand. Do not ask which is which.* He has served three decades in the Guard. He remembers the famine that came before Doom, when his village ate bark, and

the first harvest after, when the grain came up thick and green and no one said whose hands had made it so. He does not love the man who rules him. He would die for him anyway, and he does not find the contradiction troubling.

What troubles him is the fourth line. In thirty years the Guard has been ordered to kill, to arrest, to seize, to burn. It has never been ordered to hold a door open and judge. He looks down at the banners streaming up the Road of Ash and tries to guess how many will reach the Bridge. Then he tries to guess how many he hopes will.

He signals, and the first horn sounds. The war begins, and it is a real war, and every soldier on the road fights as if it were. That is also in the orders, though not on the paper.

The Road of Ash

They call it the Road of Ash because every siege in Latveria's history ended on it. It spirals up the mountain in switchbacks, three miles of cobbled causeway with a bastion on every terrace, and at each terrace the road narrows and the walls climb higher.

The Remnant surge up it in companies, banners raised, each carrying the sigil of a dead world. The Guard meet them on the first terrace. This is not a duel; it is a war, with all the noise of it. Siege-engines that are half science and half sorcery hurl bolts of crackling green. Doombots drop from battlements and land in a crouch, joints whining. Challengers fall back, regroup, push again. A company of engineers realizes that one of the great cannons fires on a rhythm and sends a runner to time the gap. A rear guard holds a switchback alone so that the others can pass. The road runs with ash, and later with something worse.

Through it all, the cicadas walk.

They are everywhere on the road, hooded figures with lanterns, moving between the lines as if the war were weather. They do not fight. They do not flee. On one terrace, a cloaked figure kneels beside a wounded challenger and sells her a map of the next bastion for a promise. On the terrace above, another cloaked figure offers a Latverian captain the same map, and the captain pays in coin. Same map. Same price. Neither of them notices that the lanterns burn the same shade.

At the third terrace, a challenger notices what the others have missed: the maps are not quite identical. A bastion drawn on one is missing from the other. Someone is lying, she thinks, and someone is paying for it. She says nothing and folds the second map into her sleeve.

Her name is Dalia, and she has spent her life learning how things that are meant to stay shut are made. In a lull behind a broken wall she spreads both maps side by side and studies them the way she once studied locks.

The bastion missing from the Remnant's map is drawn on the captain's: a squat tower full of Doombots in their racks. The captain's map is missing a narrow postern gate that the Remnant's shows in careful ink. She holds them to the light, and the lie dissolves. Neither map is false. Each is drawn from the road as its buyer sees it. The Remnant's shows what can be reached, and the captain's shows what can be held. Both are true. Neither is whole.

"A map is only true from where you stand," she says to no one in particular. Nearby, a hooded Cicada kneeling over a casualty lifts its head, as though the sentence had been addressed to it.

On the fourth terrace the Remnant find the walls carved from floor to parapet with a dense, regular script: the law of Latveria, cut in stone so no one could say it had been misremembered. Dalia presses her palm to it between volleys. The characters repeat in clusters of three, a rhythm too deliberate to be speech. She copies a handful into the margin of her map before the Guard push forward again. She does not yet know what she will need it for.

Cinematic note: a long crane shot following the road upward, switchback by switchback, with the camera drifting between battle and calm. Use the lanterns as visual anchors. The audience should start to look for the cicadas in every frame.

The Bridge of Bells

At the last switchback, the mountain splits into a gorge, and over the gorge hangs a stone bridge draped with bells.

There are hundreds of them, bronze and green with age, one for every Latverian soldier who has died defending the road. When the wind moves them, they murmur like a congregation. When someone crosses the bridge, they ring, and the pattern of the ringing matters. Doom's engineers built the bridge as a test rather than a barrier: step wrongly, and the bells scream and the gorge's winds rise, and the Doombots on the far side open fire. Step rightly, and the bells fall silent, one by one, until the crossing is a hush.

The Remnant do not know this. They learn it in the first minute, when the first company charges across and the bells roar.

The battle at the bridge is the worst of the climb. The Guard hold the far side with discipline that has no mercy in it. Challengers fall into the gorge. Others learn the bells' language by hearing it wrong. A scholar in the middle of the crowd, an old woman who once taught music in a city that no longer exists, begins to count aloud. The bells answer. Her voice becomes the rhythm of the crossing, and company after company follows it onto the span.

In the middle of the bridge stands a cloaked figure with a lantern, perfectly still. The bells around it make no sound. Soldiers on both sides of the line step around it without a glance, as though it were a lamp post.

Halfway across, Maren Voss stops counting steps and begins reading.

Every bell is stamped with a name and a date. She lays her hand on the nearest and feels the letters under her palm: a corporal, nineteen years old, who held this span against a flood of fire in a war no one outside Latveria remembers. The next is a cook who took a spear meant for a boy. The next is a captain. They are not ordered by rank. They are ordered by the day each of them fell, and when she follows the sequence she understands that the bridge was never only a lock.

It is a roll call.

The bells ring when someone crosses carelessly, because carelessness is how soldiers die. They fall silent when the crossing is made in step with the dead, each footfall landing on the rhythm of the names like an answer. She speaks the names aloud as she walks, and the bells hush after her, one by one. A challenger behind her scoffs at first, then hears his own boots fall in time, and stops scoffing.

Only the figure at the center hangs no bell. No name is owed to it, and nothing is owed to the dead on its account. The Cicada stands in a silence it did not make, lantern steady, and does not look at her as she passes.

The Remnant reach the far side with half their number. Ahead of them, the mountain ends and Castle Doom begins: black towers stacked against a sky of cracking light, the outer wall rising like a cliff.

Cinematic note: the bridge sequence plays best as a rhythm piece. Cut the battle to the beat of the bells, and let the music drop out whenever the correct pattern is struck. The silence is the reward.

Interlude: Doom Watches

In the throne room, Doom sits without moving.

The walls here are black glass, and in the glass the Road of Ash unfolds: the terraces, the cannons, the bridge, the faces of the Remnant. He has watched it all, from the first company at the gates to the last survivor on the span. He does not speak. He does not gesture. He only watches, with the stillness of a man who has been carrying something heavy for a very long time.

Once, as the old woman's voice carries the bells to silence, one of his gauntleted fingers twitches. It might be approval. It might be a tremor. He steadies the hand against the arm of the throne.

"Doom has waited for less," he says, to no one.

The throne hums beneath him, a low, constant note, like a reactor holding its breath.

Under his left hand, on the arm of the throne, lies a small thing no larger than a thumb: a knot of cord, handled so long that no pattern is left in it. It belonged to a woman who bargained badly and loved well. He does not look at it. He has not needed to look at it for decades.

He watches the glass instead, the great window behind the throne, where a hairline crack runs from sill to lintel and has not widened by a hair since the ferry set out. He watches it the way a man watches a sleeping animal he cannot afford to wake.

Act II: The Citadel

The war is behind them now, and the quiet is worse. In the courtyard of Castle Doom there are no horns, no banners, no soldiers, only the sound of their own breathing and, far overhead, the slow grinding of the sky. The Remnant have crossed the road. They have not yet crossed the house.

The Ash Gate

Beyond the bridge, the mountain gives way to stone, and the stone to the outer wall of Castle Doom. It rises two hundred feet, black and seamless, without windows or buttresses, as though it had been grown rather than built. At its foot stands the Ash Gate: a single slab of dark iron, taller than the gates of Doomstadt and plainer, with no handle, no hinge, no visible seam.

Etched into its face, in a Latverian script few outsiders can read, are three concentric rings of characters. At the center is a socket in the shape of a cicada.

The Remnant understand then what the brass seals are for.

But the seal alone does nothing. The rings are a lock, and the lock demands an answer. Behind the survivors, the Guard have re-formed on the last switchback, and the first volley of green fire arcs overhead. The challengers work with the enemy breathing down their necks: scholars reading the script, engineers measuring the rings, a former locksmith feeling the tolerances through the stone. They turn the rings by hand, one, then another. The cicada seal clicks into place.

The gate does not break. It opens, slowly, because it has been understood.

Only when the rings stop turning can Dalia read what they spell. It is a single line in Latverian, and the scholar beside her translates it under his breath: *What is held, is held for all.* None of them understands it. Not until the throne room will any of them realize it was never a boast.

Marshal Orlek stands at the edge of the courtyard as the last of the Remnant pass through. He raises two fingers to the iron of his mask, a salute rather than a surrender. “From here,” he says, “the army no longer matters.” The Guard turn, rank by rank, and withdraw, leaving the inner court to those who have earned it and those who are waiting inside.

Cinematic note: shoot the gate from behind as it opens, the Remnant silhouetted against a courtyard so large it has its own weather. Far above, the second Earth fills a third of the sky.

The Hall of Wards: Doctor Strange

The first of the guardians stands at the center of a colonnaded hall inlaid with silver sigils.

He is tall and still, dressed in a red cloak that moves as if remembering something. His hands rest at his sides, and around each fingertip a faint ring of golden light turns, slow as a clock. Doctor Stephen Strange, Sorcerer Supreme of an Earth that has not yet finished ending, regards the Remnant for a long moment. When he speaks, his voice is dry and tired and utterly without fear.

“You have come a long way to be wrong,” he says.

He does not strike first. He explains. The throne room beyond this hall is not a vault to be looted. If its seals are broken in the wrong order, by the wrong hands, the Incursion will not be stopped. It will be completed. “You will not save one world,” he says. “You will finish two.” He asks them, politely, to turn back.

One of the challengers steps forward, the engineer Ilya, and asks the question the others are thinking. “You are the Sorcerer Supreme. Why are you standing in his hall?”

Strange's gaze does not move. "Because I have seen what the world does when no one holds it," he says. "And I have seen what he does when he is left alone to hold it."

"That isn't an answer."

"No," says Strange, with a faint, dry smile. "It's a confession." He lets the golden rings turn once around his fingers. "I do not serve Doom. I stand beside him, which is a great deal harder. I have never forgiven him for what he has done, and I have never doubted what he is, and the two facts have lived together in me very uncomfortably for years. He has never once pretended to be better than he is. You would be surprised how rare that is."

They do not.

The duel that follows is not a fight in any ordinary sense. The sigils on the walls flare, and the hall unfolds into the Mirror Dimension, columns folding over columns, floor becoming ceiling. Strange conjures bands of golden light that bind and release, mandalas that spin like shields, a second hall that is the first hall reversed. The challengers cannot out-fight him. They realize, slowly, that they are not meant to. The wards are written in a language of geometry and repetition; every sigil is a clause, and every clause is a question. A mathematician reads the pattern aloud and finds the structure underneath. An archivist matches it against a design they have already seen: the cicada seal in their palms.

When the last mandala goes dark, Strange lowers his hands and, for the first time, smiles.

"Someone has been selling keys to both sides," he says. "I wonder who."

He does not call it defeat. "I have lost nothing," he says. "I have confirmed what I needed to confirm." He stands aside, and the cloak settles around his shoulders like a held breath. "I know what it cost him to keep it from tearing. The next room is not mine."

Cinematic note: the Mirror Dimension sequence is the first great set piece of the Citadel. Build it in Unreal as a continuous shot where the architecture itself performs: geometry folding along golden seams, light shifting from warm to cold, Strange moving through it with the calm of a man who has done this before.

The Chamber of Echoes: Wanda Maximoff

The corridor beyond is dark red.

It is not the red of fire or blood but something stranger, a color that seems to come from inside the eye. The walls ripple. The air tastes of static. And in the center of the corridor stands Wanda Maximoff, hands open, her hair stirred by a wind that touches no one else.

She is not hostile. She is something harder to face: she is kind.

“I know why you came,” she says. “I know what you lost.”

She lifts her hands, and the corridor fills with light. Each challenger sees it: their world, whole and alive, a street, a kitchen, a voice calling from another room. It is perfect. It is exactly as they remember it, and it is theirs to keep if they stop.

“I did this once,” Wanda says, and her voice catches. “I made a world where no one had to lose anything. It was the most beautiful thing I ever built. It was also the worst thing I ever did.” She does not need to say what it cost. Everyone in the corridor can read it in her face.

The trial is not a battle. It is a refusal. The echoes press close, warm and patient, speaking in the voices of the dead. Some challengers stop. Some reach out. And some stand, shaking, and say no, and walk through the light as though through water.

One of them sees nothing at all.

The boy who carries nothing stands in the red light with his hands at his sides, and the corridor stays empty around him. He has no street to show, no kitchen, no voice in the next room. There is nothing here for him to refuse. Wanda kneels in front of him, and for a moment the Scarlet Witch is only a woman on one knee in a corridor, looking at a child.

“I’m sorry,” she says. “I can’t give you anything. That is the cruelest part of what I do.”

“It’s all right,” says the boy. “I never had it.”

She looks at him for a long time. Then she takes his hand and walks him through the red, and none of the echoes touch him.

When the last of them has crossed, the red fades. Wanda lowers her hands.

“You did not defeat me,” she says. “You chose.” She wipes her eyes with the back of her wrist. “That was the only test I was ever going to give you.”

She turns to the rest of them, and the red softens at her feet. “Strange will tell you Doom doesn’t lie. I’ll tell you something else. When I came to him, broken, he didn’t offer comfort. He handed me a ledger and asked me to count what I had cost. No one else would let me.” Her mouth moves in something like a smile. “It was the kindest thing anyone had done for me in years.”

Cinematic note: shoot each challenger’s vision as a single unbroken take in its own color grade, warm and golden, with a sound design that breathes. When they refuse, cut hard to silence and desaturate. The red returns last.

The Static: Cassandra Nova

The lights die.

It starts at the far end of the corridor, with a hum, then a flicker, then a darkness that spreads like ink. The walls crack. Through the crack leaks a sound like a radio between stations, a hiss with a whisper in it. The air smells of ozone and old rain.

A figure steps out of the dark among the Remnant, where a moment ago no one stood.

She is slight and pale, dressed in black, her smile too bright, her eyes too still. Cassandra Nova crossed from the other Earth the only way anyone could: hidden among the Remnant, on a ferry that carried one soul too many. She looks at the Remnant with the fond contempt of a child watching ants. She looks at Strange and Wanda with something like the same fondness. She looks at the throne room doors, far down the hall, and her smile widens.

Maren Voss, who has counted every step of this night, is the first to understand. “Four hundred and thirteen,” she says, and her voice shakes. The ferry carried four hundred and twelve faces. The herald’s ledger recorded four hundred and thirteen crossings. Nobody saw the thirteenth board, because she did not board. She crossed in the dark between the lanterns, under the swarm, in the grief of the people standing at the rail. The Concord counts every crossing and judges none, and it counted her.

“You are all so busy deciding who gets to live,” she says. “Nobody has thought to ask who gets to end it.”

She wants the Incursion finished. Both worlds, gone. Not out of hatred, exactly, but out of an appetite with no name. She lifts a hand, and every Doombot in the corridor turns on the nearest living thing. She speaks a single word, and a challenger’s voice answers in her cadence. Static crawls up the walls.

“Do you know what I am?” she says, almost tenderly. “I am what is left when a mind is cut loose from everything that would have made it care. I have no world. I have no one to lose. Do you know how light that makes a person?” She smiles at the Remnant, at the sorcerers, at the sky. “You carry your dead like stones. I put mine down. That is the only difference between us, and it is everything.”

What follows is the strangest fight of the night. The Remnant, the Sorcerer Supreme and the Scarlet Witch find themselves on the same side, because no other arrangement can last more than a minute. Strange binds the static in gold. Wanda bends the red around it. The Remnant do what they have done all night: they find the pattern. The static has a rhythm. The rhythm has a source. They trace it to the crack and, together, they close it.

Cassandra does not die. She unwinds into noise, laughing, her silhouette dissolving into a hiss that slips back through the seam. The wall seals itself behind her. In the quiet, nobody speaks.

Strange meets Wanda's eyes. Wanda nods.

"She will be back," Strange says.

Cinematic note: render the static as a physical thing, a grain that crawls over surfaces and bleeds across the frame. Treat the team-up as a quiet moment, not a spectacle. The most powerful image is three groups, enemies an hour ago, standing shoulder to shoulder in the dark.

The Door of the Throne: Kristoff Vernard

At the end of the corridor stand the throne room doors.

They are tall, plain and black, without ornament, and before them stands a young man in dark armor with a face too composed for his age. Kristoff Vernard, whom Doom raised and whom the Guard obeys, studies the survivors with careful eyes.

"I have worn his mask once," he says. "When the world believed he was gone. It did not fit." He says it without bitterness. "Whoever wears it carries more than metal."

"I wore it for a season," he says. "It did not burn me. That is what frightened me. It fit well enough that no one noticed the difference, and I understood then that no one would have noticed if it had been anyone." He glances at the door behind him, black and plain. "I do not want it. But I will not hand it to someone who does."

He will not open the doors for strength. He will not open them for weapons. "There are three names," he says, "that open this door. Not the one the world uses. The ones he carries."

From the shadows behind the Remnant, a cloaked figure steps forward. The Ferryman. In one hand is a sealed page; in the other, an identical one. The Ferryman gives the first to the Remnant. The second goes to Kristoff.

"We carry," the Ferryman says. "You may both read."

Kristoff unseals his page. The Remnant unseal theirs. Both read the same three lines.

It is not Doom.

It is not one name but three, written as a riddle:

Say the name he was before the forge.

Say the name he lost.

Say the name he never forgave.

The Remnant argue in low voices, and the scholars among them argue longest, because the answers are written in no single place. They must be gathered from everything the Ferryman read on the shore: a boy, a mother, a rival. The first name is spoken, and a bar draws back inside the door. The second is spoken more softly, and another bar follows. The third comes last and reluctantly, the name of the man at the university whose calculations were right, and the final bar slides free. The doors begin to open.

Interlude: Doom Watches

In the throne room, the black glass shows the doors.

Doom sees them swing, sees the Remnant gather on the threshold. As the three names are spoken in the corridor, one after another, something shifts in the set of his shoulders. It is a very small movement. He has not heard the first of them in a very long time, and he has not said the second aloud in longer.

“Victor,” he says softly, to the empty hall.

He waits, and then, quieter still, so that even the black glass cannot hear: “Cynthia.”

For a moment the throne stops humming. Then it resumes, steady and low.

Act III: The Throne

The gates have fallen and the guardians have stepped aside. The Remnant arrive at the last threshold with fewer people than they started with and more knowledge than they know how to hold. Whatever waits beyond has been waiting for them since the decree.

The Hall of the Keystone

The doors open onto a hall that has no business existing inside a building.

It is a cathedral of black stone, a hundred paces wide and twice as long, its pillars rising into a darkness that swallows the ceiling. The floor is polished obsidian, and in it the cracked sky shines upside down. At the far end of the hall, up a staircase of a hundred steps, stands the Keystone Throne.

It is not a chair. It is a machine and a cathedral and a wound. Ribs of dark metal arch from its back to the ceiling, humming with green light. Cables as thick as a man descend from the dark and sink into its base. It looks less like a seat than like the spine of something very large. And in it, utterly still, sits Doom.

Cinematic note: this is the longest shot of the story. Start at the doors, wide, with the Remnant dwarfed by the hall. Walk the camera slowly up the staircase, step by step, with no cuts, until the throne fills the frame. Let it take two full minutes.

The green-and-iron armor is unmarked. The mask is a face and not a face: a plain, calm, merciless oval, its eye-slits glowing faintly. The cloak falls from his shoulders to the floor in folds like carved stone. He does not rise.

“You have climbed my road,” says Doom. His voice is not loud. It does not need to be. “You have crossed my bridge. You have opened my gate, passed my sorcerers and closed a wound I did not make. Doom has watched every step.”

He lifts one gauntlet, and the black glass in the walls brightens. Every face of every challenger is reflected, one by one. “I know your names,” he says. “I know what each of you lost. I know what you intend to do with what I hold.”

A pause.

“You believe it is a weapon,” says Doom. “Or a treasure. It is neither. Take it, if you can.”

The Hundred Steps

The staircase has a hundred steps, and every one of them is carved.

Ilya sees it first, because he has spent his life reading the surfaces of things. Each step bears a name and a date, cut deep into the black stone, and the names are not people. They are worlds. The first step reads like a place from the old atlases. The tenth is a world no one in the hall can place at all. By the thirtieth, the Remnant have found their own: a drowned coast, a city that burned, a plain where the wind carried ash for a year. They are climbing over the graves of the places they came from.

“He kept count,” someone says.

Nobody answers. It is the only time in the climb that the whole hall falls silent. At the top, Doom sits unmoving and does not look down. He does not need to. He has walked these steps more times than any of them can imagine, and each time he has had to choose which to step on and which to step over.

There are one hundred steps. The Remnant have counted the dead worlds in their own memory and found fewer than a hundred. The rest are names only Doom has kept.

The Seals

The throne wakes.

Panels of armor along its ribs slide open to reveal inscriptions, line upon line of glyphs layered over one another, each a seal. The Remnant see at once what they are: the same pattern, again and again, written in the language of every trial they have faced. The bells' rhythm. The Wards' geometry. The Echoes' colors. The Static's noise. The cicada in their palms. The name.

Everything they learned on the road is the key.

Doom does not make it easy. He is not a king who sits still while his defenses are unpicked. As the first seal is read, green lightning arcs from the throne and cracks across the floor. As the second falls, the pillars shift and Doombots drop from the dark, silent and precise. The third seal moves the hall itself: gravity tilts, the staircase turns, and the Remnant climb walls that were floors a moment ago. The cracks in the sky widen at each step, as if the world outside were leaning in to listen.

But each seal solved quiets the room. The lightning dims. The Doombots stand down. The gravity steadies. The Remnant climb, hand over hand and glyph by glyph, with the weight of every world they have lost pressing on their shoulders. At the top of the staircase, the last seal waits: a single plate over the heart of the throne, and it is not a lock. It is a question.

A challenger speaks the answer aloud. It is not a spell. It is the truth about why Doom has done everything he has done.

The plate opens.

The Keystone

The hum stops.

For the first time in a very long while, Latveria is silent. Doom rises, slowly, from the Keystone Throne, and the ribs of metal peel away from his back with a sound like a long breath. He stands on the top step, a tall figure in green and iron, and looks down at the Remnant.

Above the castle, the roof of the sky tears open.

The cracks that have haunted every other country reach Latveria at last. The window behind the throne fills with white light and the shape of the second Earth, so close now that its clouds are visible. The castle shakes. Dust falls from the pillars. The Remnant feel the whole mountain lean toward the other world, as if the ground itself were trying to leave.

“There was nothing in this castle for you to take,” says Doom.

He does not shout. His voice carries across the hall. “The power you came for, the power to save one world, was never stored in a vault. It has been in this room since the last world fell. It is here.” He lays one gauntlet against his chest. “The throne is not my seat. It is my spine. Since the last Incursion, Doom has held this sky alone. Not because he trusts no one. Because there was no one who could carry it.”

Silence. Strange has lowered his head. Wanda has put a hand to her mouth. Kristoff stands at the foot of the stairs, unmoving.

“You did not break my seals,” Doom says. “You answered them. Only an answer could lift the weight. That was the purpose of the road. Doom does not need an army that can fight. Doom needed to learn whether any of you could understand.”

“Every trial on this mountain was a lesson in what I carry,” Doom says. “The bridge taught you to count the cost, and to hear it. The wards taught you that an order is a promise made by many hands. The echoes taught you to refuse a perfect lie. The static taught you that the end has a voice, and that it can be answered. The gate taught you that a lock is only a question, and the names taught you that a throne is only a man in a chair.” A pause. “You have learned in one night, with an army at your heels, what I learned alone over many years. Doom does not say this to boast. Doom says it so that you will know what you are choosing.”

He turns his head toward the cracked window. “There are two skies in that glass,” he says. “Not one. You have been taught to see only your own. I have held both. The world above that glass is not an enemy. It is another people, looking up at another sky, as afraid as you are, and I have kept them from falling into you for longer than any of you have been counting. There was a man once who would have told me to ask for help. He would have been right. Doom could not have borne it, and so Doom did not ask.”

He looks at the Remnant once more. “What is held, is held for all,” he says. “Not for Latveria. Not for Doom. For all.”

He is not defeated. He is not humbled. His voice does not waver. But for the first time in the history of Latveria, someone on that staircase can hear how tired he is.

“Someone must carry it now,” he says. “One mask. One sky. Doom has carried it long enough.”

“The throne may be unseated for one hour,” he adds, “and no longer. That is not a threat. It is arithmetic. After the hour, the weight must be on someone’s shoulders, or the sky will find its own way down.”

He raises both hands to the mask.

Cinematic note: from here, never show his face. Stay behind him, over his shoulder, or in silhouette against the white light of the tearing sky. Let the audience imagine what is there.

The mask comes away with a faint metal sigh. He does not turn. He lets it go.

It falls.

It strikes the obsidian with a note like a great bell, pure and long, and the sound rolls through the hall and into the mountain and out across the world. The mask lies face-up on the floor, glowing a dull orange, as if it had just been lifted from the forge.

Doom turns away, a dark figure against the burning sky. Strange and Wanda step quietly to either side, and the camera never finds his face.

“Choose,” he says, to the room, to the Remnant, to the sky.

Then he walks into the shadow behind the throne, and the glow of the mask is the only light left in the hall.

Interlude: Doom Watches

He does not leave.

In the dark behind the throne, in the narrow gallery that overlooks the hall, Doom stands with his back against the cold stone and his face turned from the light. Below him, the Remnant look at the mask. Beyond them, the sky holds, barely, like a breath.

He has watched this country for decades. He has watched worlds fall. He has watched the best people he has known make the wrong choices, and the wrong people make the right ones. He does not know what he will see next.

He watches anyway.

Final Act: The Mask

Doom has gone into the dark and left behind the only thing that matters. The Remnant have won the room. They do not yet know what it costs.

The Ledger

The Remnant stand in a ring around the mask, and no one touches it.

It glows on the obsidian like a coal. The hall is silent, but the sky is not. Through the great window the second Earth hangs close enough to count its rivers, and the cracks spread across it like a held breath about to be released. The mountain shivers. Far below, the Guard have stopped fighting. Everything is waiting.

The Ferryman steps out of the shadows. Beside the Ferryman stands another cloaked figure the Remnant have never seen: shorter, quieter, carrying a ledger bound in dull brass. The Notary. They bow to the room, to Strange and Wanda, to the gallery above where a shadow watches.

“We carry,” the Ferryman says. “We do not choose. But we have kept count.”

The Notary opens the ledger and reads in a flat, exact voice. Every company that crossed the Road of Ash is recorded: every bell silenced, every ward read, every refusal in the Chamber of Echoes, every seal answered on the stairs. The ledger has no opinions. It has only numbers, and the numbers have an order.

The rules are simple, and they are terrible. The mask can anchor a single world. The Remnant came from many dead worlds, and each company carries the last memory of one: its streets, its songs, its people. Whoever bears the mask will hold the sky, and the world they hold in mind will be the pattern the sky remembers when the Incursion closes. One world. One pattern. The others will fade into the record of what was.

“Only one of you can wear it,” the Notary says. “That much is true.” A pause. “What no one has told you is that the mask does not choose the strongest. It warms to the truest.”

Dalia, the locksmith, steps out of the ring with both of her maps crumpled in one fist. “You sold us,” she says. “You gave him our names, and you sold both sides the same road.”

“We gave him your names,” the Notary agrees. “Because the mask reads names. A world that arrives unrecorded cannot be held by anyone. The roster was not betrayal. It was a petition.” The Notary lifts the brass ledger a little. “And we sold both sides the same road

because it was one road. You drew your map from your side of the wall. The captain drew his from his. We drew them both, and both were true. A record that favors one hand is not a record. It is a leash."

Dalia stares at the ledger, at its exact, indifferent columns. "And the thirteenth name?" she says. "The one nobody boarded with?"

"We recorded her too," says the Notary. "It is the price of being unable to choose."

Dalia does not answer. After a moment she smooths the two maps flat against her thigh and folds them together, one inside the other.

Somewhere in the walls, a thin hiss of static slides along the stone. A voice, very faint, threads itself through the quiet: *only one, only one, only one*. The Notary does not look up. "Ignore her. She is not wrong. She is only not finished."

The Contest

Strange raises one hand, and the Hall of the Keystone changes. It does not change violently. The pillars slide aside, the obsidian floor rises into a lattice of black glass, and hundreds of mirrors unfold from the walls and hang in the air like a field of dark flowers. Wanda breathes red across the lattice, and it hardens into a boundary no one can cross.

"No blood," Strange says. "Not here. The hall will not allow it."

What remains is a contest of everything else.

The companies break into factions, then alliances, then rivalries. They have climbed together for hours; now the knowledge they shared becomes the weapon each will use against the others. A company that decoded the bells hides its key. Another quietly sabotages a ward-lattice so a rival's answer comes out wrong. A third offers an alliance and withdraws it at the last moment. Every mirror in the hall reflects a different version of the same race, and in every version the mask pulses brighter for whoever has given the truest answer.

Three moments hold the room.

A company from the drowned coast, led by Ilya, builds a counter-ward out of three stolen answers and a theory, and it nearly works. The mask brightens toward them, then cools sharply, because one of the three answers was a guess passed off as knowledge. Ilya sees the dimming and says so aloud. He lays out exactly which answer was the guess. The mask warms again, a little, for the honesty.

A second company seizes a mirror and finds it shows only a flattering version of their own plan. They cannot tell whether they are studying the mirror or the mirror is studying them. Wanda, from the edge of the lattice, speaks without turning. “The mask was made by a man who swore he would never be fooled again. It will not warm to a lie, even a good one.”

And Maren Voss, who never wanted to win anything, sits down in the middle of the lattice and begins to hum the rhythm of the bells. The mirrors nearest her stop spinning. The dark flowers fold. She does not reach for the mask. She does not look at it. But for a moment the whole hall breathes in time with an old woman trying to remember the dead, and a competitor from a rival company, lunging for a shortcut, stops with one hand in the air, then quietly sits down beside her.

High above, the gallery is dark. But the black glass in the walls follows every move, and every so often the throne hums a single low note, as if someone were keeping time.

The tear in the sky widens by an inch each minute. Dust rains from the ceiling. Nobody looks up.

Cinematic note: shoot the contest as a chess match in a hall of mirrors. Keep the camera low and let reflections stack until it is impossible to tell which faces are real. Use the mask as the only warm light in a cold frame, brightening and dimming as the lead changes hands.

The Titles

When the hour ends, the Notary opens the ledger to its last page and reads three names.

The first company is the one that laid hands on the mask and kept it. They are called the **Doombreaker**. The second is the company that razed the last of the seals and took the Citadel by answer instead of force. They are called the **Citadel Razer**. The third is the company that kept its light burning when every other company went cold, the last to give up and the last to let the ember die. They are called the **Ember of Latveria**.

The brass cicada in each of their palms changes color: gold for the Doombreaker, silver for the Citadel Razer, ember-red for the Ember of Latveria. The other companies lower their eyes. None of them are forgotten. All of them are written down.

The Choice

The Doombreaker takes up the mask.

It is heavier than it looks and hotter than it should be, and it does not burn. Through the window the sky holds its breath.

When the Doombreaker looks into it, the hollow of the mask is not dark. It holds two skies. They hang one above the other, close enough to touch, each thick with the lights of a world that has no idea it is being held apart from the other. A hundred names run through the glow like a pulse. And at the center, small as a pinprick, a boy on a mountain with a woman's knotted cord in his hand.

The weight is not on the head. It is in the knowing. In the gallery above, a silhouette stands without moving, waiting to see what a person does when they understand exactly what they are being asked to carry.

There are two choices, and both are true. The Doombreaker may put it on, and become the keystone, carrying the sky as Doom has carried it, bearing a world in mind until the end of their days. Or the Doombreaker may carry the mask up the steps to the gallery where a shadow waits, and give it back.

No one can make the choice for them. It is the last unscripted act of the story.

Epilogue: The Ember After

If the Mask Is Returned

The Doombreaker climbs to the gallery with the mask in both hands.

Doom steps out of the dark. He does not take it at once. He looks at it for a long time, and then at the person holding it, and in the white light of the tearing sky he is only a silhouette. He takes the mask with the care of a man lifting a sleeping child.

"Doom was always going to carry it," he says. His voice is quieter than it has ever been. "Doom needed to learn whether the world could."

He sets it on his face. It is still warm. The ribs of the Keystone Throne rise from the dark and close behind him, and the hum returns, steady and low. The sky above the castle draws shut, crack by crack, and the second Earth recedes until it is only a pale disc above the mountains. It is not gone. It is delayed. But delay is a thing the world can use.

"You will be remembered," says Doom. "In Latveria, that is not a small thing."

If the Mask Is Worn

The Doombreaker lifts the mask and sets it on their face.

The ember brightens, and a new note rings through the hall, higher than the old one. The throne rises behind them. The ribs of metal settle against a spine that was not made for them. Light pours through the window, and the sky, for the first time in ages, draws quietly shut.

In the gallery above, Doom steps into the light without his mask, his face turned from the room. He walks down the stairs, past the Remnant, past Strange and Wanda, through the open doors and out into the corridor. For the first time in the history of Latveria, no one sees him leave.

Dawn Over Latveria

Morning comes slowly, and it is gray.

On the battlements of Castle Doom, Strange and Wanda stand side by side, watching the pale disc of the second Earth settle toward the horizon. Neither speaks. When Strange finally turns to go, Wanda touches his sleeve. “She’s not gone,” she says. He nods. In the cracked glass of a window behind them, a hiss of static curls, and for one moment a voice that is not a voice says *not finished*.

Kristoff Vernard stands alone at the top of the steps. Below him, the Guard are folding their banners. He looks at the empty throne for a long time. Then he takes his place beside it, as he has always done.

At the Bridge of Bells, Maren Voss does not go down with the others. She stays on the span through the gray of the morning, reading the names stamped into the bronze one by one, her hand flat against each bell before she speaks it. The corporal. The cook. The captain. Some are strangers to her. Some were enemies. All of them held a bridge for a man who would not let anyone else carry the cost. She reads until she runs out of bells. The Cicada at the center, who has not moved all night, bows its head very slightly at the last one.

At the black lake, on a platform half-drowned in the dawn, the Ferryman and the Notary stand together. The ledger is open to its last page. At the bottom, in a hand as thin as a thread, is a single number: **3301**.

“Both sides read the same map,” the Ferryman says. “That was the only way it could be true.”

The Notary closes the ledger. Far across the water, the cicadas begin to sing.

On the far side of the sky, at a station that looks exactly like this one, another lantern goes out. The people on that platform lower their eyes from the heavens and look at one another for the first time in days. A cloaked figure writes a last line in a ledger, and the line reads exactly like the one on this shore.

The Last Watch

On the highest balcony of Castle Doom, a tall figure stands in green and iron, looking out over the land.

His cloak moves in the wind. The mask is on, plain and calm. In the mountains below, the road is empty, the bells are silent, the bridge is still. In every window of every Latverian house, the lamps are lit.

He does not speak. He does not need to. But somewhere out there, on every road and in every ruin, the Remnant look up, and for a moment each of them feels it, as surely as the weight of the sky: the unblinking regard of a man who has seen every step they took.

Doom has been watching.

Doom will always be watching.

Appendix A: Story Plants for the Challenge Layers

Every element below is a narrative object that can double as the surface of a challenge. The story is the first layer; the technical subject is the second; the lore correlation that connects them is the third.

- **3301 and the Prime Hour.** The Cicada Concord's number is prime, and the insects emerge on prime-numbered cycles. Seeds: number-theory ciphers, prime-based key derivation, serial numbers stamped on the brass seals.
- **The Dossier.** Every fact the Ferryman reads aloud (the monastery, the forge, the mother, the rival) is a potential passphrase or OSINT thread. Players who skim it will be stuck later.
- **The Two Tolls.** The ferry's manifest and the herald's ledger disagree by exactly one name: four hundred and twelve faces boarded, four hundred and thirteen crossings were recorded. Seeds: diffing documents, forensics, finding the entry that has no face.
- **The Two Maps.** The maps sold on the Road of Ash differ in two places, each true from its buyer's side of the wall. Neither is false; neither is whole. Seeds: image and file comparison, hidden layers.

- **The Bridge of Bells.** The ring pattern is a lock. Seeds: audio, Morse or binary encoding, spectrogram steganography. A wrong crossing yields noise; a right one yields silence.
- **The Ash Gate Rings.** Three concentric rings in a fictional script. Seeds: substitution ciphers, key derived from the cicada seal.
- **The Hall of Wards.** Sigils as clauses. Seeds: geometry, graph structures, cipher text hidden in mandala patterns.
- **The Chamber of Echoes.** Memories that should be refused. Seeds: corrupted logs, memory dumps, recovering the one true record among perfect fakes.
- **The Static.** A signal hidden in noise. Seeds: frequency analysis, signal extraction, channel noise.
- **The True Name.** The door opens to three names, not a title: the boy, the mother and the rival. Seeds: lore research, a multi-part passphrase that cannot be guessed from the title alone.
- **The Keystone Seals.** The final gauntlet reuses every earlier key in order. Seeds: chained, multi-stage challenges where each plate demands one prior solution.
- **The Mask's Bell.** The note struck by the falling mask is the last flag. Seeds: an audio file whose frequency or hash is the final answer.

Added in the deepened draft:

- **The Terrace of Letters.** Latverian script carved on the fourth terrace, and the same glyph clusters on the Ash Gate rings. Seeds: a substitution cipher built from a lore-derived alphabet, frequency analysis.
- **The Roll of Bells.** Names and dates stamped on the bronze, ordered by the day each person fell. Seeds: decoding, ordering by date, a message read in the order the dead fell.
- **The Thirteenth Crossing.** One ledger entry with no face. Seeds: counting, diffing, hidden entries.
- **The Hundred Steps.** Each step carries a world's name and a date. Seeds: sorting, date arithmetic, step numbers used as an index into another text.
- **The Three Names.** The boy, the mother, the rival. Seeds: lore research, each name unlocking one stage of a multi-part passphrase.

Appendix B: The Cicada Concord and the Club Team

The Concord is neutral, but its role is minimal and critical on both sides. The organizers can appear in the story as its officers.

- **The Ferryman** opens the event, runs the prologue and delivers the seals. Without the Ferryman, no one crosses.
- **The Cartographer** sells hints and maps to every team at the same price, with a cost in points. A hint is never free and never exclusive.
- **The Herald** is Doom's voice. Live announcements, decree reminders and scoreboard updates are read in the voice of a court that is always watching.
- **The Notary** keeps the ledger, which is the scoreboard. The Notary is the final judge of rank and the one who reads out the three titles.
- **The Static** is the wild card: a rogue event, a surprise challenge, an Easter egg that appears between acts and belongs to no side.

In every role the same rule applies: the Concord carries and does not choose.

Appendix C: The Thirteen Questions

Each question is planted before the scene that answers it, and each can be solved from the story's own clues or from the lore it borrows.

#	Question	Planted	Answered	Where players must dig
1	Why is Latveria's sky the only one still whole?	Prologue, The Last Station	Act III, The Keystone	What Doom kept after losing the God-power
2	Why does Doom open his border at all?	Prologue, The Decree	Act III, The Keystone	The decree's wording; who needs whom
3	Why exactly one hour?	The Decree, the fireside debate	Act III, "arithmetic"	Time ciphers; the ferry's Prime Hour
4	Why does a neutral order sell the same road to both sides?	Act I, The Road of Ash	Final Act, The Ledger	Comparing the two maps by perspective
5	Why does the ledger hold one name too many?	The Crossing	Act II, The Static	Manifest versus ledger: count the crossings

#	Question	Planted	Answered	Where players must dig
6	Why do the bells fall silent around the Cicada?	Act I, The Bridge of Bells	The bridge and Dawn	Names and dates stamped on each bell
7	Why do Strange and Wanda stand beside Doom?	Act II, Wards and Echoes	Act II confessions, Act III	Secret Wars-era Strange; Wanda's reality-rewrite
8	What did Doom lose, and what stayed?	The Dossier, Maren's question	Act III, The Keystone	Secret Wars aftermath
9	Why does the door want three names?	Act II, The Door of the Throne	Interlude, Doom hears them	Victor, Cynthia von Doom, Reed Richards
10	What is on the other Earth, and who watches it?	Prologue, The Other Shore	Act III and Dawn	Incursion lore; the mirrored ferry
11	Why does the mask warm to the truest, not the strongest?	The Dossier (the vow)	Final Act, The Contest	The mask's forging; the vow
12	What does Cassandra Nova want, and why is she not finished?	Act II, The Static	Dawn Over Latveria	Her origin as Xavier's twin
13	Who is the Concord, and why does it count?	Prologue, The Cicada Concord	Dawn: the ledger closes on 3301	Primes, cicada cycles, the number 3301